



Pompeii

Julian Vance

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First Edition

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Chapter 1

Martha sat in front of the stove oven methodically cleaning its inner surfaces. Parts of bread and flesh from last night's feast still clung to the edges articles to a ship.

Her mind often wandered from the monotonous task and this time was no exception. She often wandered into past memories predominantly those of horrors she had witnessed in her twenty years.

The memories came and went, staying a while before another would replace it. One memory Martha did not particularly like often stayed fo long periods refusing to move on. This was the memory John, her husband.

She could remember it like it had happed yesterday when in reality it happened more than a year ago.

The starved, half-crazed animal could think of nothing more than its prey. A young well built man. It's mouth watering hungrily as it surged toward its prey paying no attention to the cheering crowd.

The crowds surrounded the stadium occupying every vacant seat.

Martha sitting beside her cruel master, had been forced to watch the episode as it unfolded.

This was her husband's punishment for attempted escape and his master was sending a clear message to any other slaves attempting escape. He had failed in his attempt and now here he was about to be devoured by a lion. And she could do nothing about.

She sat their utterly helpless too stunned to cry. She wanted to close her eyes but the restraining hand of her master made think again and she

with much effort was able to keep her eyes open.

The lion now only a few paces away, was positing his body for the highlight the lunge. John stood trembling his inadequate armor weighing heavily on his starved but strong body.

With a earsplitting gour it jumped ludged forward its mouth open ready to tear into its unlucky prey. The crowd cheered loudly experrated at the prospect of seeing death.

John made no effort to fight knowing who would win in the end he laid down his sword and stood waiting for the inevitably jaws of the on-coming animal.

He didn't have long to wait the huge animal fell on him its huge claws tearing large gauges in tanned brown skin.

A few moments later he lay motionless.

Tears welled up in the eyes Martha unable to hold them back she let a few dribble out and they landed with a splatch on her white white tunic.

Her bysitter noticing the tears quickly exclaimed,

"Hey you don't do that or you'll be next."

After the incident her master had not loosened his firm grip on her but only increased. He put upon her shoulders burdens a woman of her age should carry. Even a slave.

She looked up, her supervisor stood towering over her, his immense height making Martha look like a mouse at the mercy of a lion. He held in his left hand a large leather whip. An article which he used often when a servant did the slightest thing wrong.

He looked down and could immediately sense the free written all over her young work worn face.

"Why aren't you done cleaning that oven!" he yelled. Commanding her to answer she replied in a faltering voice,

"Well, I'm almost done, see looked." she pointed at the area she had already covered. She begin scrubbing vigorously trying desperately to finish before her supervisor used the whip.

"Well I'm almost down," she pleaded still rubbing vigorously. After she proved she was indeed working he decided to let her go and moved on. A wave of relief washed over young Martha, she could still feel the scars from the last time he had chosen to strike more than the a week ago. The memory was still vivid.

She had been preforming a routine task much like the one she was now. She had risen and to get a drink when the surpivisor entered. She had been completely taken off guard and quickly hurried back to her task but now before he had given her strict scolding. She thought she would get by

with just a scolding but how wrong she was. The whip can come at her its leather end curling she had impulsively lifted her arms shielding her face but that had not slowed the whip. It continued hurling toward her and she could do nothing about it. She screamed but the whip did not listen to the commands of its victim and only leaned to the commands of his operator. It hit her hard and she screamed unable to hold the boiling pain in her back.

This was too the great enjoyment of her torturer. He went at her again, this time his whip traveling at higher speeds and therefore stronger impact which made her boil with pain.

She could still feel that scar, although not as bad as it had hurt it still throbbed.

Martha finished her task and quickly moved onto the more enjoyable job of cooking.

Martha did enjoy cooking which was very beneficial considering her position was head cook of the house. Visitors to the house often commented on her cooking saying it was the best they had ever tasted.

She glanced out the window at the crowds of jostling people passing by the mansion carrying a large array of fruits, vegetables, meats, and other everyday foods. Some were leading vulnerable animals such as sheep and cows toward the butcher where they would soon turn into someone's Supper. Still others carried furniture and other household items.

The bustle and noise outside the small window was unending. People walked the streets at all hours.

Often her master would host large parties many of the guests being traveling visitors from faraway Rome.

Vacationers were common in Pompeii and many a time Martha had noticed some rich citizen or politician stay in this house.

Her mind lurched back to her current task. Her master was planning a banquet for that night and she was responsible for preparing that banquet. This would require many hours of hard labor preparing all of the delectable foods the Pompeians enjoyed.

Martha had but one helper to assist in her kitchen duties, a young girl barely 14, named Motaat.

Motaat, like Martha, had been born in Rome and had been relocated to Pompeii where she had been bought by Martha's master and brought to the mansion.

Motaat had not taken long to learn the difficult trade of preparing food and now was an expert doing her work without prompting from Martha. Martha didn't know what she would do without Motaat.

To pass the time they often conversed together talking about different matters rarely about food.

Martha dipped her pitcher into the large cistern located just outside the kitchen and returned to the kitchen. She hefted the large canister onto the counter and let out a slight grunt.

Mutaat busied herself dressing a lamb which she had bought in the forum a day ago. She would cook in the large oven later this afternoon. The morning flew by and Martha hardly knew it was prandium until Motaat called,

“Prandium is ready.”

The simple meal of bread and leftover meat was arrayed in the center of the large kitchen. Around in the kitchen sat all the domestic workers already hungrily munching on the leftover food. The men drank watered down wine well the woman were forced to survive on water.

The talked little, everyone absorbed in their own thoughts and not venturing into that of others.

Martha couldn't help thinking of her dear deceased husband. If he hadn't attempted escape he too could be here enjoying prandium with her and others. Talking joyfully and keeping the conversation going which now was at a constant standstill.

She soon finished her meal and returned to her strenuous task. She had finished the days bread baking and was about to help Motaat finish dressing the lamb when she heard a scream.

She whirled around and to her horror she saw Motaat topple and land with a thud on the ground, unconscious and then she felt it.

The earth under her strong and stable feet grew unstable skating violently as if it was threatening to open and swallow her.

She was terrified and wanted to scream just like Motaat but with all effort she restrained. She also had to battle the everchanging ground keeping her balance and not tumbling to the ground like Motaat. These two efforts combined drained much of Martha's energy and she was not ready for what happened next.

She stumbled toward the window leaning heavily on the supporting wall, when she finally made it the sight she beheld was one of pure horror.

The street once bustling but calm was now a sight of chaos. People and animals ran, clogging the streets. The weakest people were left falling behind the jostling crowd shouting biterrally in anguish. The new arrivals trampled over these fallen making it impossible for them to regain their height. These seen alone held the attention of the onlooker for more than a

second before she finally searched for a cause of the chaos.

She looked up, above the once peaceful Mt. Vesuvius was now replaced by a menacing black cloud blocking the sun entirely. Small bits of ash and embers flung themselves upon Pompeii completely obliterating everything in their path. And Martha soon found why everyone was running toward the bay, Pompeii was being destroyed and she was right in the middle.

Motaat still lay, unconscious and Martha wondered if she should try and revive the girl but the thought soon vanished and the more prominent thought of escape replaced it. She wanted to scream to run forever, and get away from this horrible place, away from Mt. Vesuvius away from the ash and embers that still rained like raindrops. But her legs did not share her wishes, they would not budge but flatly refused and kept their position at the window.